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Words and the Dogon world

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62. Yebene says that raindrops and seeds merge in his mind, that “they are exactly the same thing.”

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63. The “twin” head is created from two heads on the same stalk. The “split” stalk is older because, it is said, twins were at first one (androgynous); in the same way, the Lebe snake is older than the bínu snake because it was already in existence when rain fell on the earth.

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64. The blessing is: “It is Amma who leads you. May Lebe be your companion; may the father bínu be your companion; may the ancestors (lit. gínna, threshold) be your companions; may Amma make the salt of the rain fall upon your head drop by drop.” It is said that it is the Lebe snake who asks Nommo for rain; indeed it is from Lebe that rain is sought if it is late for planting. (Previously, it was requested from the pool in a ritual called úguru.) When the planting is done, rain becomes “the matter of the Earth,” thus of Lebe.

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65. In fact two strings are used for making calculations. On the first a knot is tied each year at alternating ends, beginning with the year after the sígi. The second is used to count only thirty years before the ceremony. Counting begins as soon as one sees "the firelight in the cave of Yuogo" (Griaule 1938b:167ff).

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66. Less today.

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67. Relations between the kú,nǒ and twins are maintained by a sort of "joking relationship" (mà[unavailable]u). They traditionally exchange jokes on this theme. For example, the first will say: "The kú,nǒ is important because he is pure. Twins are slightly impure (pùru) because they follow a menstrual period. They are gluttons. The little brother followed the first because he was afraid he would not have enough to eat." The others retort: "Any woman can claim to have had a kú,nǒ; all she need do is to hide her menstrual period ■281 and not go to the pùnulu. But not everybody can have twins!" and so it continues.

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Births

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